
RESEARCH BRIEF — FOR CAREGIVERS

Geragogy for Caregivers

The science of helping an older adult learn — and how to be a
useful supporter without becoming the help desk

A research brief from mynaani — September 2026

Executive summary

Most older adults do not lack the ability to learn new technology. What they often lack is a learning experience designed for how they learn. The science that explains this is called **geragogy**: the study of teaching and learning in later life. It is not "slower" pedagogy or "simpler" content. It is a distinct discipline that takes seriously how aging changes vision, attention, working memory, and confidence.

For family caregivers, geragogy matters because you are usually the person an older adult turns to first. Research on family technology support shows that younger family members play evolving roles — influencer, supporter, protector, monitor — throughout an older adult's learning journey. How you support matters as much as whether you support. The wrong help can create dependence, tension, or avoidance. The right help can build the older adult's own confidence to the point where they no longer need help.

This brief is a practical guide to that science. It explains the mechanisms that make standard technology difficult for older learners, the principles that help, and how to apply them as a caregiver without becoming the person the older adult depends on for every new tool.

1. What geragogy is — and what it is not

Geragogy is the theory and practice of learning in later life. It differs from pedagogy, which is the teaching of children, and from andragogy, which is the teaching of adults. Geragogy adds what andragogy often misses: the measurable ways that aging changes the conditions of learning.

It is also not a style. "Senior-friendly" usually means larger buttons, slower speech, or simplified vocabulary. Those are accommodations. Geragogy is a method: it starts from the older learner's actual perception, attention, memory, and confidence, and it designs the entire learning environment around preserving their dignity and autonomy.

The core commitments — predictability, dignity, reversibility, confidence preservation, and containment of cognitive load — are not politeness. They are the conditions under which learning remains possible.

2. The four changes aging makes in learning

Decades of peer-reviewed research converge on four mechanisms. Each one has practical meaning for anyone helping an older adult learn.

Vision. By age 80, typical contrast sensitivity is roughly 80% lower than at age 20. Presbyopia and reduced retinal illumination mean small type, low contrast, and dense screens are not just harder to read — they cost more attention. What is "a little hard to see" for a younger reader can be effectively illegible for an older learner (W3C WAI; Owsley, *Annual Review of Vision Science*).

Attention. Aging reduces inhibitory control: the brain's ability to suppress irrelevant information. Decorative motion, pop-ups, badges, and dense layouts are not background noise for older learners; they are processed, and they degrade comprehension and memory for what matters (Hasher & Zacks, 1988; Campbell, Hasher & Thomas, 2014).

Working memory and cognitive load. Cognitive load is the dominant mediator of digital-learning outcomes in older adults. In a 2025 *JMIR* experiment on digital health education, load correlated negatively with learning performance at a large effect size. Every unfamiliar icon, unexpected state change, or multi-step detour spends working memory that was meant for the material.

Confidence, or self-efficacy. Confidence is the strongest predictor of whether an older learner persists. The good news: it is trainable. Randomized controlled research (Laganà et al.) shows that age-appropriate, self-paced technology training significantly improves attitudes and self-efficacy. The goal of help is not to get the task done; it is to increase the older adult's belief that they can get the next task done themselves.

3. The caregiver's role: supporter, not substitute

A 2022 study by Tang and colleagues in *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* is especially useful for caregivers. In interviews with 20 older adults and 18 younger family members in China, the authors identified four roles that younger family members play over the course of an older adult's technology learning:

- **Influencer** — shaping the decision to try a new technology.
- **Supporter** — explaining, demonstrating, and helping practice.
- **Protector** — worrying about scams, privacy, and safety.
- **Monitor** — checking in, managing settings, or limiting access.

These roles are not fixed. They evolve as the older adult's skills and online activity change. A new tool can push a caregiver from supporter to monitor. A security scare can intensify the protector role. A mismatch between what the caregiver thinks the older adult can do and what the older adult believes they can do can lower the older adult's intention to keep learning.

A 2025 *Heliyon* study of 182 older-adult/caregiver pairs confirmed this. Technology use intention was highest when the caregiver's and the older adult's beliefs about the older adult's capability matched. When they did not, use dropped. This means that support that signals "you cannot do this" — even well-meaning support — can backfire.

The practical implication: your role is to help the older adult become their own learner, not to become the person who must handle every tool.

4. What helps: principles for caregiver support

Start with the learner's self-view

Ask what they want to do, not what they "should" learn. Older adults learn best when the goal is theirs and the pace is theirs. If the gift or tool does not match a goal the older adult already cares about, it will sit unused.

Give worked examples before open-ended tasks

The worked-example effect is one of the most robust findings in instructional science (Kalyuga). Show the process first; then let them try. Do not hand them a blank screen and ask them to figure it out.

Use plain language and predictable steps

Avoid jargon. Name buttons with words, not icons alone. Keep the sequence the same every time. If a step must change, explain why. Predictability is not boring; it is the foundation of confidence.

Remove evaluative pressure

No tests, grades, timers, streaks, or badges. Evaluative pressure consumes working memory and sends a signal of judgment. For an older learner, that signal can end the learning.

Let them stop, reverse, and repeat

Reversibility is central to geragogy. Every action should feel undoable. The recipient should be able to pause and come back without penalty.

Be available, then step back

Offer help, but do not hover. The Tang study found that successful support was collaborative, not continuous. The measure of good support is that the older adult needs less of it over time.

5. What to look for in a learning program

If you are choosing a program for an older adult — whether as a gift or a recommendation — five tests follow from the research:

- **Is it built for older learners, or adapted to them?** Look for design choices traceable to geragogical research, not just larger text.
- **Does it build self-efficacy?** Ask how it protects and increases the learner's confidence, not just their completion rate.
- **Does it control cognitive load?** Are screens sparse? Are transitions predictable? Are icons paired with words?

- **Does it avoid borrowed pressure?** Tests, timers, and gamification are evidence of a method built for a different age group.
- **Is it honest about evidence?** Programs that cite sources and acknowledge limits are safer than programs that promise transformation.

6. Conclusion and next step

Geragogy is the difference between helping an older adult survive a new tool and helping them become confident with it. For caregivers, that means your support is most powerful when it is temporary, dignified, and aimed at the older adult's independence.

Mynaani was built on geragogical principles. If you are considering it as a gift, the brief *Gifting AI Learning* explains the research behind the purchase. If you would like to learn more about supporting an older adult's technology learning, or request this brief for your team or family, write to **hello@mynaani.com**.

About mynaani

Mynaani is an AI learning program designed specifically for adults 55+, built on geragogical principles and a patent-pending cognitively-protective interface. We have an interest in the conclusion of this paper; readers should weigh it accordingly. Every statistic cited is third-party and verifiable below.

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